

WALK BY THE SPIRIT

*Renewing the Mind, Taking Every Thought Captive,
Meditating on the Word, and Bearing the Fruit*

A Deep Scripture Study with Greek and Hebrew Word Notes

Don't be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may prove what is the good, well-pleasing, and perfect will of Elohim.

ROMANS 12:2

But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you won't fulfill the lust of the flesh.

GALATIANS 5:16

Every one of us walks somewhere. The question is never whether we are walking, it is what we are walking by. Paul says there are two ways to live: by the flesh or by the Spirit. And the place where that battle is won or lost, over and over, every single day, is the mind. What you set your mind on is where your feet will go. What you meditate on is what you will become. And what you become will show up as fruit that everyone around you can see.

This study walks through the whole picture in order: what it means to walk, the war between Spirit and flesh, how the mind is renewed, how thoughts are taken captive, how meditation on the Word plants us, what it means to set our minds on things above, and what grows out of a life like that. Along the way we will look at the Greek and Hebrew words, because the words themselves preach.

Scripture is quoted from the World English Bible (WEB), divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai.

SECTION I

What It Means to Walk

Scripture uses walking as the picture of a whole life. Not a single step, not a Sabbath, not a good day at the Midrash, but the direction you are going and the pace you keep, day after day.

The Words

הלך *halak*. Hebrew: to walk, to go, to travel. Used for the whole course of a life. "Enoch walked with Elohim" (Genesis 5:24). Walking with Him is the oldest picture of relationship in the Book.

περιπατέω *peripateo*. Greek: literally to walk around (peri, around, plus pateo, to tread). Paul's ordinary word for how a person conducts their life. Used in Galatians 5:16 and Romans 8:4.

στοιχέω *stoicheo*. Greek: to walk in line, to keep in step, from *stoichos*, a row or a rank. Used in Galatians 5:25. This is soldiers in formation or a traveler matching the steps of a guide.

If we live by the Spirit, let's also walk by the Spirit.

GALATIANS 5:25

Notice Paul uses two different words. In verse 16 it is *peripateo*, the everyday walking around of life. In verse 25 it is *stoicheo*, keeping in step. The Spirit sets the pace and the direction, and we fall in line behind Him. Walking by the Spirit is not a feeling you wait for. It is a choice to match His steps, one step at a time.

Life by the Spirit is the gift. Walking in step with the Spirit is the response.

SECTION II

Spirit and Flesh: Two Ways to Live

For the flesh lusts against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh; and these are contrary to one another, that you may not do the things that you desire.

GALATIANS 5:17

The Words

רוח / רוח / רוח *ruach / pneuma*. Breath, wind, spirit. The same Ruach that hovered over the waters in Genesis 1:2 is the breath of life Elohim put into the man, and the Spirit He puts within His people.

בשר / בשר *basar / sarx*. Flesh. Sometimes it simply means the body. In Paul's teaching it often means human nature living on its own appetites, apart from Elohim. Your body is not the enemy. The flesh as a ruler is.

The flesh and the Spirit want opposite things, and you cannot serve both at the same time. That is why the walk matters so much. You are always feeding one of them.

For those who live according to the flesh set their minds on the things of the flesh, but those who live according to the Spirit, the things of the Spirit. For the mind of the flesh is death, but the mind of the Spirit is life and peace; because the mind of the flesh is hostile towards Elohim; for it is not subject to Elohim's law, neither indeed can it be.

ROMANS 8:5-7

φρονέω / φρόνημα *phroneo / phronema*. To set the mind on, to think in a settled direction; *phronema* is the mindset itself. Not a passing thought, but the bent of the whole inner life. Romans 8:5 and 8:6.

Look closely at verse 7. The fleshly mind is hostile toward Elohim and is not subject to His instructions. Paul uses the word *nomos*, which points back to the Torah. Which means the opposite is also true: the mind of the Spirit is not at war with His instructions. That is exactly what YHWH promised through Ezekiel.

I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes. You will keep my ordinances and do them.

EZEKIEL 36:27

that the ordinance of the law might be fulfilled in us, who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit.

ROMANS 8:4

The Spirit does not lead you away from YHWH's instructions. He writes them on your heart and walks you into them.

For if you live after the flesh, you must die; but if by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body, you will live. For as many as are led by the Spirit of Elohim, these are children of Elohim.

ROMANS 8:13-14

SECTION III

Renewing the Mind

Don't be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may prove what is the good, well-pleasing, and perfect will of Elohim.

ROMANS 12:2

The Words

συσχηματίζω *syschematizo*. To be conformed, to be pressed into a mold or a pattern (from schema, an outward shape). The world has a mold, and it will press you into it if you let it. The same word appears in 1 Peter 1:14.

μεταμορφώω *metamorphoo*. To be transformed, changed in form from the inside out. The word behind our English metamorphosis. It is the same word used when Yahshua was transfigured before the disciples (Matthew 17:2), and in 2 Corinthians 3:18.

ἀνακαίνωσις *anakainosis*. Renewing, making new again. Also used in Titus 3:5 for the renewing of the Holy Spirit.

νοῦς *nous*. The mind: the faculty that perceives, understands, judges, and decides.

Here is something the English hides. In the Greek, “be transformed” is a present tense, passive command. Present tense means it keeps happening, it is ongoing. Passive means it is done to you. You do not transform yourself by willpower. You yield, and He transforms you. But it is still a command, which means you can choose to put yourself in the place where that renewing happens or you can resist it.

Conformed is pressure from the outside. Transformed is change from the inside. The world shapes you by pressure. The Spirit changes you by renewal.

that you put away, as concerning your former way of life, the old man, that grows corrupt after the lusts of deceit; and that you be renewed in the spirit of your mind, and put on the new man, who in the likeness of Elohim has been created in righteousness and holiness of truth.

EPHESIANS 4:22-24

ἀνανεόω *ananeoo*. To be renewed, made young again. Ephesians 4:23. Its only use in the New Testament.

and have put on the new man, who is being renewed in knowledge after the image of his Creator,

COLOSSIANS 3:10

Put off, be renewed, put on. That is the pattern. Renewal is not just getting rid of the old thinking. If you only empty the house, it stays empty (Matthew 12:43-45). You have to fill it with truth. Renewal is being restored to the image you were created in, the identity Yahshua came to give back.

But we all, with unveiled face seeing the glory of Adonai as in a mirror, are transformed into the same image from glory to glory, even as from Adonai, the Spirit.

2 CORINTHIANS 3:18

SECTION IV

Casting Down Imaginations and Taking Every Thought Captive

For though we walk in the flesh, we don't wage war according to the flesh; for the weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh, but mighty before Elohim to the throwing down of strongholds, throwing down imaginations and every high thing that is exalted against the knowledge of Elohim, and bringing every thought into captivity to the obedience of Messiah;

2 CORINTHIANS 10:3-5

The Words

ὄχυρωμα *ochyroma*. A stronghold, a fortress. Used only here in the New Testament. In the Greek Old Testament it is used for walled cities and military fortresses.

καθαίρέω *kathaireo*. To pull down, demolish, tear down. The same root is used for taking Yahshua's body down from the execution stake (Mark 15:46). It is a present participle here: we keep tearing down.

λογισμός *logismos*. The word the King James translates "imaginations." It means reasonings, calculations, arguments. From logizomai, to reckon or count. A stronghold is built out of reasonings.

ὑψωμα *hypsonoma*. A high thing, something lifted up. Every proud thought that raises itself above what Elohim has said.

αἰχμαλωτίζω *aichmalotizo*. To take captive as a prisoner of war. From aichmalotos, a captive taken in war, which is built on aichme, a spearpoint. You do not negotiate with a thought like this. You arrest it.

νόημα *noema*. A thought, a design, a purpose of the mind. Paul says every one (pan noema).

Read verse 5 slowly and you will see that Paul defines his own terms. What are the strongholds in verse 4? Verse 5 tells you: reasonings, and every high thing lifted up against the knowledge of Elohim. A stronghold is a fortress of thinking. A lie believed long enough becomes a wall. A wall lived behind long enough becomes a fortress. And the enemy loves to set up camp inside a fortress we built for him.

Pride builds the stronghold. Humility tears it down. The high thing must come down before the healing can come in.

The Hebrew Picture: Imagination

יצר *yetzer*. A form, a framing, the shape something is molded into. From yatzar, to form, the word used when YHWH formed the man from the dust (Genesis 2:7). The yetzer is what the heart forms and shapes.

YHWH saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every imagination of the thoughts of man's heart was continually only evil.

GENESIS 6:5

You will keep whoever's mind is steadfast in perfect peace, because he trusts in you.

ISAIAH 26:3

Here is the beautiful part. The word translated “mind” in Isaiah 26:3 is that same word, *yetzer*. The imagination that was only evil continually before the flood can become a *yetzer samuk*, a mind that is leaned on, propped up, resting on YHWH. And the Hebrew says He keeps it in *shalom shalom*, peace doubled. The imagination does not need to be destroyed. It needs to be taken captive and leaned on Him.

SECTION V

Meditating on the Word

This book of the law shall not depart from your mouth, but you shall meditate on it day and night, that you may observe to do according to all that is written in it; for then you shall make your way prosperous, and then you shall have good success.

JOSHUA 1:8

The Words

הגה *hagah*. To meditate, but the word is not silent. It means to mutter, to speak under your breath, to growl. In Isaiah 31:4 it is used for a lion growling over its prey, refusing to let go even when the shepherds shout at it. That is Biblical meditation.

שיח *siach / sichah*. To ponder, consider, talk over; sichah is a meditation. Psalm 119:15 and 119:97.

Notice Joshua 1:8 says the book shall not depart from your *mouth*. Hebrew meditation is speaking the Word over and over until it gets into you. It is not emptying your mind, it is filling it. Eastern meditation tells you to empty yourself. YHWH tells you to fill yourself with what He said, and to chew on it like a lion that will not let go of its meal.

Blessed is the man who doesn't walk in the counsel of the wicked, nor stand on the path of sinners, nor sit in the seat of scoffers; but his delight is in YHWH's law. On his law he meditates day and night. He will be like a tree planted by the streams of water, that produces its fruit in its season, whose leaf also does not wither. Whatever he does shall prosper.

PSALM 1:1-3

Psalm 1 ties this whole teaching together. It starts with **walking**: the blessed man does not walk in the counsel of the wicked. It moves to **meditating** on YHWH's instructions day and night. And it ends with **fruit**. Walk, meditate, bear fruit. The tree does not strain to make fruit. It is planted by the water, and fruit is what happens.

I have hidden your word in my heart, that I might not sin against you.

PSALM 119:11

How I love your law! It is my meditation all day.

PSALM 119:97

Let the word of Messiah dwell in you richly; in all wisdom teaching and admonishing one another with psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, singing with grace in your heart to Adonai.

COLOSSIANS 3:16

What you meditate on, you will become. What you rehearse, you will repeat.

SECTION VI

Setting the Mind on Things Above

If then you were raised together with Messiah, seek the things that are above, where Messiah is, seated on the right hand of Elohim. Set your mind on the things that are above, not on the things that are on the earth. For you died, and your life is hidden with Messiah in Elohim.

COLOSSIANS 3:1-3

ζητέω *zeteo*. To seek, to search for, to go after. Verse 1. This is the pursuit.

φρονέω *phroneo*. To set the mind. Verse 2. The same word from Romans 8:5. Seeking is what you chase; setting the mind is where you let your thoughts settle and live.

Thinking on heavenly things does not mean floating away from your real life. Look at what Paul does next in Colossians 3. Right after "set your mind on things above" he gets very practical: put to death sexual immorality and covetousness, put away anger, slander, and lies, put on compassion, kindness, humility, forgiveness, and love. A heavenly mind produces an earthly walk that looks like heaven.

Finally, brothers, whatever things are true, whatever things are honorable, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report; if there is any virtue, and if there is any praise, think about these things.

PHILIPPIANS 4:8

λογίζομαι *logizomai*. To think about, to reckon, to take into account, to keep counting. Notice it is the root of logismos from 2 Corinthians 10:5. The reasonings that built the stronghold get torn down, and new reckoning takes their place.

Paul's filter. Before you entertain a thought, ask:

- Is it **true**?
- Is it **honorable**?
- Is it **just** (right)?
- Is it **pure**?
- Is it **lovely**?
- Is it of **good report**?
- Does it have **virtue**?
- Is it worthy of **praise**?

And notice what comes right before verse 8. Verses 6 and 7 say do not be anxious, bring everything to Elohim in prayer with thanksgiving, and the peace of Elohim will *guard* your hearts and your thoughts (noemata, the same word from 2 Corinthians 10:5). Prayer posts the guard. Philippians 4:8 decides what is allowed through the gate.

SECTION VII

The Fruit of the Spirit

Now the deeds of the flesh are obvious, which are: adultery, sexual immorality, uncleanness, lustfulness, idolatry, sorcery, hatred, strife, jealousies, outbursts of anger, rivalries, divisions, heresies, envy, murders, drunkenness, orgies, and things like these; of which I forewarn you, even as I also forewarned you, that those who practice such things will not inherit Elohim's Kingdom.

GALATIANS 5:19-21

But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faith, gentleness, and self-control. Against such things there is no law. Those who belong to Messiah have crucified the flesh with its passions and lusts.

GALATIANS 5:22-24

פרי / καρπός *peri / karpos*. Fruit. What a living tree naturally produces from what it is rooted in.

Look at the grammar. The flesh has **deeds**, *erga*, plural, works you produce. The Spirit has **fruit**, *karpos*, singular. One fruit with nine flavors. You do not get to pick the ones you like and skip the rest. When the Spirit is ruling, all of it grows together. Works are manufactured. Fruit is grown.

The Nine

ἀγάπη *agape*. Love. Self-giving love that chooses the good of another. The root the rest grow from.

χαρά *chara*. Joy. Gladness that does not depend on circumstances. Related to charis, grace.

εἰρήνη *eirene*. Peace. Carries the weight of the Hebrew shalom: wholeness, nothing missing, nothing broken.

μακροθυμία *makrothymia*. Patience. Literally long of temper, slow to boil. The Greek Old Testament uses makrothymos in YHWH's own description of Himself in Exodus 34:6, "slow to anger" (Hebrew erekh apayim).

χρηστότης *chrestotes*. Kindness. Goodness that is useful, gentle in how it treats people.

ἀγαθωσύνη *agathosune*. Goodness. Uprightness that acts, goodness that does something.

πίστις *pistis*. Faith, faithfulness. Trust in Elohim that becomes being trustworthy yourself.

πραΰτης *prautes*. Gentleness, meekness. Strength under control, not weakness. Yahshua called Himself gentle (Matthew 11:29).

ἐγκράτεια *enkrateia*. Self-control. Literally having power within, holding the reins of your own appetites.

"Against such things there is no law." No instruction of YHWH has ever been against love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, or self-control. The fruit of the Spirit and the instructions of YHWH are not enemies. The Spirit grows in you the very character the Torah describes.

Remain in me, and I in you. As the branch can't bear fruit by itself, unless it remains in the vine, so neither can you, unless you remain in me. I am the vine. You are the branches. He who remains in me, and I in him, the same bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing.

JOHN 15:4-5

You do not produce fruit by trying harder. You produce fruit by staying connected. The branch's job is to remain.

SECTION VIII

Putting It All Together: The Daily Walk

Everything in this study is one movement, not seven separate subjects. Here is how it fits together, in the order Scripture lays it out:

- **Recognize** the thought. Ask Philippians 4:8: is it true? Is it pure? Does it line up with what Elohim said? (Philippians 4:8)
- **Refuse** the lie and tear down the high thing. Arrest it and bring it to the obedience of Messiah. Do not entertain it, do not argue with it, take it captive. (2 Corinthians 10:5)
- **Replace** it with the Word. Speak the scripture out loud. Put off, be renewed, put on. (Ephesians 4:22-24)
- **Rehearse** the truth. Meditate day and night, muttering it, growling over it like the lion. (Joshua 1:8, Psalm 1:2)
- **Raise** your mind. Set it on things above, where Messiah is. (Colossians 3:1-2)

- **Remain** in the Vine. Stay connected and walk in step with the Spirit, and the fruit will come in its season. (John 15:5, Galatians 5:25)

This is also why forgiveness matters so much in deliverance. Unforgiveness is a stronghold made of reasonings: what they did, what they owe, why I am right to hold it. Pride raises it up as a high thing. As long as that fortress stands, the mind keeps rehearsing the wound instead of the Word. Tear it down, take those thoughts captive, forgive, and the ground is cleared for fruit to grow.

Walk by the Spirit, and you won't fulfill the lust of the flesh. That is not a threat. It is a promise.

SECTION IX

Handling These Verses Accurately

These are common teaching points that get stretched. Teaching them carefully makes the message stronger, not weaker.

Proverbs 23:7. “As a man thinks in his heart, so is he” is often quoted as a proof text for the power of positive thinking. In context it is a warning about a stingy host who says “eat and drink” but is counting the cost of every bite (Proverbs 23:6-8). The WEB renders it “as he thinks about the cost, so he is.” The verse is real wisdom about the heart revealing the man, but it should not be used as a promise that thinking something makes it so.

2 Corinthians 10:3-5. In context Paul is answering opponents in Corinth and their arguments against his authority and the knowledge of Elohim. The first application is tearing down false teaching. Applying it to our personal thought life is fair, because Paul says *every* thought, but the primary meaning is arguments and proud reasonings, not only random intrusive thoughts.

“Strongholds.” Paul defines the strongholds in the very next verse as reasonings and every high thing raised against the knowledge of Elohim. Demonic oppression can certainly attach to those places, but the text itself locates the stronghold in the mind. Teach the definition Paul gives.

Galatians 5:18. “If you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law” is often read as the Spirit replacing YHWH’s instructions. Reading it alongside Galatians 3:10-13, Romans 8:4, and Galatians 5:23, the position taught here is that being “under law” refers to being under its curse and condemnation, not to walking in the instructions. That is an interpretation of Paul’s argument, and it should be presented as such.

Hebrew meditation. *Hagah* does mean to mutter or growl, and Isaiah 31:4 really does use it of a lion. That makes speaking the Word aloud a strong picture, but it is not a rule that silent reflection is wrong. Psalm 119 also uses *siach*, to ponder and consider.

SECTION X

Reflection and Discussion

- What has been pressing you into the world’s mold lately? Where does that pressure come from?
- What reasoning have you lived behind long enough that it has become a wall? What would it look like to tear it down?

- Which thought do you need to arrest this week and bring to the obedience of Messiah?
- What one scripture will you mutter and growl over day and night this week?
- Of the nine flavors of the fruit, which one is the hardest for you right now? What does that tell you about where you need to remain closer to the Vine?
- Is there anyone you need to forgive so the stronghold of unforgiveness can come down?

SECTION XI

Cross Reference Index

Walking. Genesis 5:24; Psalm 1:1; Romans 8:4; Galatians 5:16, 25; Colossians 3:7

Spirit and Flesh. Ezekiel 36:26-27; Romans 8:5-14; Galatians 5:17-21, 24

Renewing the Mind. Romans 12:1-2; 2 Corinthians 3:18; Ephesians 4:22-24; Colossians 3:9-10; Titus 3:5

Thoughts Captive. Genesis 6:5; 2 Corinthians 10:3-6; Philippians 4:6-7; Isaiah 26:3

Meditation. Joshua 1:8; Psalm 1:2-3; Psalm 119:11, 15, 97; Isaiah 31:4; Colossians 3:16

Things Above. Colossians 3:1-17; Philippians 4:8-9

Fruit. Psalm 1:3; Matthew 7:16-20; John 15:1-8; Galatians 5:22-23

Accuracy Notes. Proverbs 23:6-8; Galatians 3:10-13; Matthew 12:43-45

Your Notes

